

Guide to Rebuttals

The Rebuttal Speeches in a debate round are extremely important because it ideally offers the judge closure in the round and a highlighting of your most important arguments and/or issues in the round.

General Observations:

- As a rule, you should try to avoid extensive new analysis (although not expressly forbidden) and absolutely avoid brand new arguments (expressly forbidden and grounds for a Point of Order).
- Rebuttals are ideal for clarifying the main issues of your side of the debate.
- Avoid the urge to rehash the previous 31 minutes of debate in your *four or five-minute* rebuttal.
- Your rebuttal should highlight the “voting issues,” items in the debate that your team has won, and why your side has won the debate.
- A successful rebuttal strikes a balance between “the big picture” and individual issues in the debate.

A Great Rebuttal:

- Giving a great rebuttal starts with your listening and flowing skills, being present in the debate. You simply cannot respond to arguments that you did not hear or did not capture on your flow.
- If you find that you are missing key points in the debate, practice flowing and responding to recorded debates. Listening and flowing different people, and their speaking styles, will help you be more adaptable in rounds.
- A great rebuttal is all about issue selection. Remember that you need not win every issue in the round to win the debate. You need to win the most significant issues important to your side in the debate. Issue selection is about finding what issues are must win, and arguing why your side has won those issues.
- A great rebuttal is all about issue selection, and a rebuttal speech usually has 2-4 issues that become the main voting issues. These are typically the arguments that you need to win for your team to win.
- Those who become great at rebuttals have “round vision.” Which is the perspective to see the whole round as it is happening but to also have the perspective of the whole debate and where you want to take it in the end.
 - The Chess metaphor: You start with all the pieces on the table and position them as needed to make a checkmate. You may lose pieces and make sacrifices, but you are always trying to think several moves ahead. This is the same in debate, you start with a strong case and through the course of the debate you make moves to position your important issues for the rebuttal.

The Member Speech:

- A great rebuttal starts with a solid member speech. The member is tasked with responding to the opponent’s arguments and strengthen your own. Being able to preempt your opponent’s arguments weakens their position as they go into the rebuttal. Having a sense of what they might go for in their rebuttal will strengthen your arguments in the member speech.